

California Preschool/Transitional Kindergarten

Learning Foundations

At-a-Glance



For Three-to-Five-and-a-Half-
Year-Old Children in Center-Based,
Home-Based, and TK Settings

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For more information about the foundations and for examples of how children demonstrate the skills and behaviors in the foundations, please refer to the full version of the California Preschool/Transitional Kindergarten Learning Foundations.



Approaches to Learning

Strand: 1.0 — Motivation to Learn

Sub-Strand — Curiosity and Interest

Foundation 1.1 Curiosity and Interest

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Express interest in some familiar and new objects, people, and activities in their immediate environment. Seek information by exploring with their senses, describing their observations, and asking simple questions.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Express interest in a broader range of familiar and new objects, people, and activities by exploring more extensively with their senses, describing their observations in greater detail, and asking more detailed questions.

Sub-Strand — Initiative

Foundation 1.2 Initiative

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Demonstrate initiative by starting activities (such as simple play scenarios), initiating social interactions (such as helping others), and seeking solutions to problems.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Demonstrate initiative by starting activities (such as detailed and more complex play scenarios), initiating social interactions (such as helping others) more often, and seeking solutions to problems more persistently.

Sub-Strand — Engagement

Foundation 1.3 Engagement

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Actively engage by focusing and concentrating on activities for brief periods of time with adult support.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Actively engage by focusing and concentrating on activities for longer periods of time with less adult support.



Sub-Strand — Perseverance

Foundation 1.4 Persisting Despite Difficulties

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Demonstrate persistence, with adult support, when engaging in an activity despite encountering setbacks or boredom. Make an effort, with adult support, to cope with emotions that arise (for instance, frustration, sadness, anger, excitement), although may shift to another activity after a short while.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Demonstrate persistence for longer periods of time when engaging in an activity despite encountering setbacks or boredom. More consistently cope with emotions that arise (for instance, frustration, anger, sadness, excitement) and can continue engaging in an activity with less adult support.

Strand: 2.0 — Executive Functioning

Sub-Strand — Working Memory

Foundation 2.1 Working Memory

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Hold approximately one to two pieces of information in their mind for a short time and use the knowledge to guide behavior when performing tasks and engaging in play, with adult support.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Hold approximately two to three pieces of information in their mind for longer periods of time and use the knowledge to guide behavior when engaging in multistep tasks and more complex play, with less adult support.

Sub-Strand — Inhibitory Control

Foundation 2.2 Managing Impulsive Behaviors

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Demonstrate emerging ability to manage habitual reactions (habits that are not useful in a particular context), impulsive behaviors (acting on a whim), and delaying gratification (resisting temptation for an instant reward) with adult support.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Manage habitual reactions (habits that are not useful in a particular context), impulsive behaviors (acting on a whim), and delaying gratification (resisting temptation for an instant reward) with less adult support.



Foundation 2.3 Managing Attention and Distractions

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Demonstrate an emerging ability to ignore distractions and interruptions during independent or group activities; however, often need adult support to manage attention when distracted or interrupted.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Demonstrate an emerging ability to ignore distractions and interruptions during independent or group activities with less adult support.

Sub-Strand — Flexibility

Foundation 2.4 Flexibility

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Demonstrate emerging ability to shift behavior and think about things in a new way, with adult support.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

More consistently shift behavior and think about things in a new way, with less adult support.

Strand: 3.0 — Goal-Directed Learning

Sub-Strand — Problem-Solving

Foundation 3.1 Planning

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Demonstrate emerging ability to set and carry out simple goals (for example, one- to two-step plans and goals), with adult support.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Demonstrate ability to set and carry out more complex plans (for example, two- to three-step plans and goals), with less adult support.

Foundation 3.2 Reflecting and Analyzing

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Make attempts to adjust a problem-solving approach or strategy by reflecting on and analyzing their current approach, with adult support.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Make attempts to adjust a problem-solving approach or strategy by reflecting on and analyzing their current approach, with less adult support.



Sub-Strand — Collaborative Effort

Foundation 3.3 Problem-Solving Together

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Collaborate with peers in problem-solving during play and learning activities, sometimes for a short period of time and sometimes longer.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Engage in extended collaborative problem-solving during play and learning activities. Communicate with peers about how to solve a problem and help peers when needed.

Foundation 3.4 Understanding Others

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Notice, with adult support, that others have different approaches and preferences, although often have difficulty accepting others' approaches or preferences.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Demonstrate understanding and explain that others can have different approaches and preferences and more consistently accept others' approaches and preferences, with less adult support.



Foundational Language Development

This is one out of two sub-domains in the Language and Literacy Development domain.

Strand: 1.0 — Listening and Speaking

Sub-Strand — Vocabulary

Foundation 1.1 Understanding and Using Vocabulary

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Understand and use words for objects, actions, and attributes frequently experienced in everyday life, such as through play, conversations, or stories.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Understand and use an increasing variety of words for objects, actions, and attributes experienced in everyday life, such as through play, conversations, or stories.

Foundation 1.2 Understanding and Using Words for Categories

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Understand and use commonly experienced vocabulary to describe categories and the relationships within them.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Understand and use increasingly specific vocabulary to describe categories and the relationships within them.

Foundation 1.3 Understanding and Using Size and Location Words

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Understand and use words to describe the size and location of objects (such as “tiny” and “on”), including simple comparisons (such as “bigger”).

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Understand and use increasingly specific words to describe and compare the size and location of objects (such as “longer” and “between”).



Sub-Strand — Grammar

Foundation 1.4 Using Grammatical Features and Sentence Structure*

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Use common word forms and sentence forms to express thoughts and ideas.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Use both common and less common word forms and sentence forms to express complex thoughts and ideas.

Foundation 1.5 Asking Questions

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Use questions to seek information and to clarify and confirm understanding.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Use questions and follow-up questions to seek information and to clarify and confirm understanding.

Foundation 1.6 Constructing Narratives

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Use language to construct real or fictional short narratives.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Use language to construct real or fictional extended narratives that have several details or a plotline.

Foundation 1.7 Sharing Explanations and Opinions

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Share descriptions, opinions, and explanations.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Share detailed descriptions, opinions, and explanations.

* Refer to the full draft of the PTKLF for additional information on how this foundation develops depending on the languages children are learning.



Foundation 1.8 Participating in Conversations

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Participate in back-and-forth conversations with adults and peers. Respond on topic for at least one turn in a conversation.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Participate in increasingly long and complex back-and-forth conversations with adults and peers. Respond on topic across several turns in the conversation.

Strand: 2.0 — Foundational Literacy Skills

Sub-Strand — Phonological Awareness

Foundation 2.1 Isolating Initial Sounds

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Match words that have the same first sound in speech, with adult support or the support of pictures or objects.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Isolate and pronounce the first sound of a word, with adult support or the support of pictures or objects.

Foundation 2.2 Recognizing and Blending Sounds*

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

When presented with two single-syllable words (such as “sand” and “box”), blend them into a compound word in speech with adult support or the support of pictures or objects.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

When presented with syllables and individual sounds, blend them into words in speech with adult support or the support of pictures or objects.

Foundation 2.3 Participating in Rhyming and Wordplay

Early (3 to 4 ½ Years)

Recognize or participate in familiar rhymes or songs.

Later (4 to 5 ½ Years)

Produce rhyming sounds or words. Rhymes may be imperfect and can be real or nonsense words.

* Refer to the full draft of the PTKLF for additional information on how this foundation develops depending on the languages children are learning.



English Language Development

This is one out of two sub-domains in the Language and Literacy Development domain.

Strand: 1.0 — Listening and Speaking

Sub-Strand — Vocabulary

Foundation 1.1 Understanding Words

Discovering

Pay attention to English oral language and understand a few common English words, while relying mainly on intonation, facial expressions, and gestures of the speaker in interactions with adults and peers.

Developing

Demonstrate understanding of words in English for objects and actions as well as phrases encountered frequently in interactions with adults and peers.

Broadening

Demonstrate understanding of a larger set of words in English (for example, objects and actions, personal pronouns, possessives, and descriptive terms) in interactions with adults and peers.

Foundation 1.2 Using Words

Discovering

Use English words, mainly consisting of concrete nouns.

Developing

Use varied English words, including an increasing number of concrete nouns and some verbs and pronouns.

Broadening

Use a wide variety of English words to share knowledge of concepts, including words across all parts of speech, with some inaccuracies.

Sub-Strand — Grammar

Foundation 1.3 Using Grammatical Features

Discovering

Use one or two familiar English verbs as all-purpose verbs, with some inaccuracies.

Developing

Use some grammatical rules in English, such as using -s or -es for plural nouns and -ing for verbs, sometimes with inaccuracies.

Broadening

Broaden the use of English grammatical rules, such as irregular plurals or simple past tense verbs, sometimes with inaccuracies.



Foundation 1.4 Using Complex Sentence Structures

Discovering

Use words or phrases repeatedly experienced in English to communicate.

Developing

Use a few formulaic English sentence structures to communicate on a range of topics by switching out key words in a phrase.

Broadening

Use a variety of English grammatical forms, with some inaccuracies, to produce many different types of sentence structures.

Grammatical forms can include adding appropriate possessive pronouns (for example, *your*, *my*); conjunctions (for example, *and*, *or*); and other elements (for example, adjectives, adverbs).

Sub-Strand — Language Use

Foundation 1.5 Communicating Needs

Discovering

Use single English words and nonverbal communication with English speakers, such as gestures or behaviors, to seek attention, make a request, or initiate a response.

Developing

Combine nonverbal communication and some English phrases to be understood by English speakers.

Broadening

Show increasing reliance on verbal communication in English to be understood by English speakers.

Foundation 1.6 Understanding Requests and Directions

Discovering

Follow simple directions in English when given additional contextual clues.

Developing

Follow directions in English that involve repeatedly experienced routines or contextual clues.

Broadening

Follow directions that involve more than one step, relying less on contextual clues.



Foundation 1.7 Asking Questions

Discovering

Use a frequently experienced question phrase (such as “What’s that?”) or use one or two English words with a rising pitch to ask questions.

Developing

Use a few question structures as a formula, filling in different words to ask about various topics.

Broadening

Use “who,” “what,” “why,” “how,” “when,” and “where” to produce questions in many forms to ask about a variety of topics in English.

Foundation 1.8 Constructing Narratives

Discovering

Identify parts of real or fictional narratives using a few English vocabulary words.

Developing

Construct real or fictional short narratives using English vocabulary in a few simple English sentence structures.

Broadening

Construct real or fictional narratives by stringing together sentences with varied structures in English.

Foundation 1.9 Sharing Explanations and Opinions

Discovering

Use English vocabulary and gestures to share descriptions, opinions, and explanations.

Developing

Use a few simple sentence structures to share descriptions, opinions, and explanations.

Broadening

Use varied sentence structures to share descriptions, opinions, and explanations.

Foundation 1.10 Participating in Conversations

Discovering

Engage in conversation with English speakers, by mostly listening and responding with a few English words, gestures, or other nonverbal responses.

Developing

Converse with others using frequently heard vocabulary in English, often using short, commonly used sentences and phrases and a few repeated grammatical structures, sometimes with inaccuracies.

Broadening

Engage in conversations in English using increasingly complex vocabulary and varied grammatical structures, sometimes with inaccuracies.



Strand: 2.0 — Foundational Literacy Skills

Sub-Strand — Phonological Awareness

Foundation 2.1 Recognizing and Segmenting Sounds

Discovering

Recognize and produce sounds of spoken English.

Developing

Match English words that have the same first sound in speech, with adult support or the support of pictures or objects.

Broadening

Isolate and pronounce the first sound of a word in English, with adult support or the support of pictures or objects.

Foundation 2.2 Recognizing and Blending Sounds

Discovering

Recognize and produce sounds of spoken English.

Developing

When presented with two single-syllable English words (such as “sand” and “box”), blend them into a compound word in speech, with adult support or the support of pictures or objects.

Broadening

When presented with syllables and individual sounds, blend them into English words in speech, with adult support or the support of pictures or objects.

Foundation 2.3 Participating in Rhyming and Wordplay

Discovering

Attend to and participate in frequently experienced simple songs, poems, and fingerplays in English, with gestures and some key words.

Developing

Repeat or recite parts of simple songs, poems, and fingerplays that emphasize rhyme in English.

Broadening

Repeat, recite, produce, or initiate simple songs, poems, and fingerplays that emphasize rhyme in English.



Sub-Strand — Alphabets and Print*

Foundation 2.4 Recognizing and Identifying Letters

Discovering

Recognize the first letter in their own name in the English alphabet.

Developing

Accurately identify a few letters of the alphabet in English.

Broadening

Accurately identify many uppercase and some lowercase letters of the alphabet in English.

Foundation 2.5 Learning Letter–Sound Correspondence

Discovering

Demonstrate awareness that English alphabet letters have sounds.

Developing

Accurately identify or produce the sound associated with one or two letters in the English alphabet.

Broadening

Accurately identify or produce the sounds of a few letters of the English alphabet (about 5–10), with adult support.

Sub-Strand — Concepts About Print*

Foundation 2.6 Understanding the Concept of Print

Discovering

Interact with materials representing the letters of the English alphabet.

Developing

Demonstrate awareness that they are interacting with English print.

Broadening

Demonstrate awareness of English print as something that can be read and has specific meaning.

* Refer to the full draft of the PTKLF for additional information on how this foundation develops depending on the languages children are learning.